

ASTROLOGY

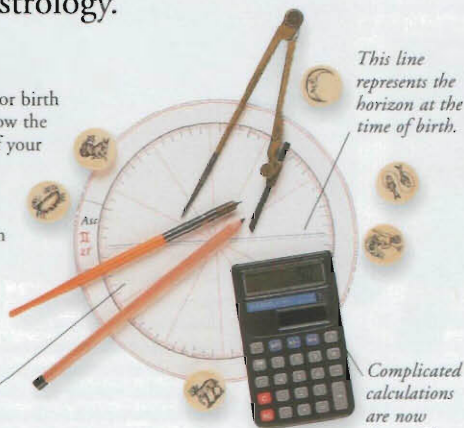


FOR CENTURIES, people have believed that the position of the stars and planets has an influence on human life. The study of this influence is known as astrology. It began about 4,000 years ago in Mesopotamia (modern Iraq) and eventually spread throughout the ancient world. In most cultures astrology was regarded as a science, and many rulers even used astrology when making important political decisions. Today, although there is no scientific proof for its accuracy, many people still believe in astrology.

Casting a horoscope

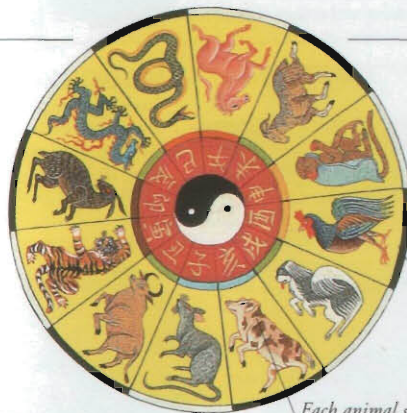
To draw up your horoscope, or birth chart, astrologers need to know the exact date, time, and place of your birth. They then use careful calculations to plot the position of the Sun, Moon, and planets. Astrologers claim that they can interpret the finished horoscope to reveal your character.

The chart is divided into 12 houses, one for each zodiac sign.



This line represents the horizon at the time of birth.

Complicated calculations are now done with calculators.



The five elements

Water Wood
Earth Fire Gold

Each animal sign is linked to one of the five elements.

Astrological wheel

Chinese astrology features 12 animals, and each represents a different personality type. For example, people born in the year of the Snake are said to be sociable, confident, and energetic.

The black and white bands represent the Universe's balancing forces of yin and yang.



Associations

Each astrological animal is associated with a certain food, colour, and symbol. The Rat's symbol is the set of balances, its colour is black, and it is linked with salty-tasting foods.

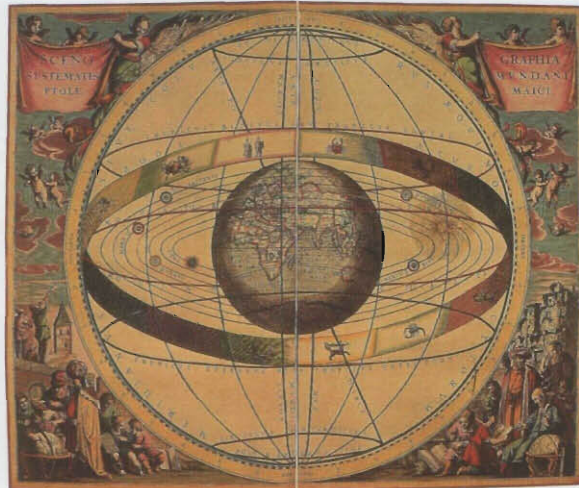
Chinese horoscopes

Unlike Western astrology which is based on the movement of the Sun and planets, Chinese horoscopes are based on the cycle of the Moon. Each Chinese year is named after a different animal – the Rat, Ox, Tiger, Rabbit, Dragon, Snake, Horse, Ram, Monkey, Rooster, Dog, and Pig.

Astrology and astronomy

The scientific study of stars and planets is known as astronomy. For thousands of years, astronomy and astrology were closely linked. From the 17th century onwards, however, leaps in scientific knowledge resulted in astronomy becoming increasingly important, while belief in astrology began to wane.

An early telescope



Astrological map showing the view of the universe in 1660.

Twelve signs of the zodiac

Celestial spheres

Ancient astrologers believed that the Universe was a gigantic sphere, with the Earth at the centre and the stars circling around it. They divided this sphere into 12 sections, each of which was named after a constellation of fixed stars – the signs of the zodiac.

Signs of the zodiac

Each sign of the zodiac takes its name from ancient mythology. Early astrologers chose names to suit the shapes formed by the constellations – the stars that make up Leo, for example, were thought to resemble a lion.



Fortune telling

People's desire to see into the future has given rise to many different forms of prediction, which vary from culture to culture. They include crystal ball gazing, dream interpretation, palmistry, divination sticks, tarot reading, runes, numerology, and the I Ching, an ancient Chinese oracle.

The role of chance

Many fortune-telling systems use dice, coins, or cards to introduce an element of randomness.

Throwing dice is an ancient way of making predictions.



I Ching coins

Consulting a fortune teller in Hong Kong



Palmistry

Each person's palm is unique, with its own distinctive pattern of lines. Palm readers believe these markings reveal the owner's character, past and future. As well as both palms, the palmist examines the fingers and nails.



Palmistry hand

Tarot cards

Tarot cards are found worldwide. They can be dealt in many different ways, and are thought to answer specific questions, or be a guide to the future.



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